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ARTICLE

The Chatbot In The Bible Study: Who Is Discipling Christians Now?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 21, 2026

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Millions of people are bringing questions about Scripture to artificial intelligence every week. They want help understanding difficult passages, comparing interpretations and making sense of what the Bible says.

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OpenAI's analysis found that about 22 million weekly ChatGPT requests focus on studying religious texts. Nearly half of Christianity-related messages concern Bible passages, while another 13% involve worship, sermons or church practices.

Those numbers do not tell us how many people are growing in faith, attending church or turning away from it. They do show that AI has become a place where people are asking spiritual questions. For the Church, the question is no longer whether people will use these tools. It is whether they will learn to use them with wisdom—and whether a chatbot is becoming the first voice they trust.



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reasons someone might ask AI about the Bible. A person can type a question at any hour, ask for a passage to be explained in simpler language, or request background on a place, person or custom mentioned in Scripture. They can ask follow-up questions without worrying that they will sound uninformed.

For someone new to Christianity, that accessibility may be valuable. A reader who encounters a confusing passage can get a starting point for further study. A parent can ask for questions to guide a family discussion. A small-group leader can use AI to organize ideas or find themes to investigate.

But an answer that is easy to get is not automatically an answer that is sound. AI can produce a clear, confident explanation while missing the passage's context, blending competing interpretations or presenting a mistaken claim as fact. A user may not know enough to spot the difference.

That is especially important with Scripture. A verse can be made to appear to say almost anything when separated from the surrounding chapter, the rest of the Bible and the historic beliefs of the Church. A chatbot may summarize a passage, but it does not carry the spiritual responsibility of teaching it faithfully.



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Convenience Is Not Discipleship

The deeper issue is not simply whether AI can answer Bible questions. It is whether people are beginning to confuse receiving information with being discipled.

Christian faith is not only a set of facts to collect or verses to interpret. Discipleship involves learning to follow Christ in community, being corrected when we misunderstand, growing in prayer and service, and allowing Scripture to shape our lives. It includes relationships with people who know us and can walk with us through difficult questions.

A chatbot can respond to a question about forgiveness. It cannot reconcile with someone on our behalf. It can generate a prayer, but it cannot pray as a believer. It can offer general advice about grief or conflict, but it does not know the full story or bear responsibility for the counsel it gives.

That distinction matters when people turn to AI with questions they might otherwise bring to a pastor, parent or trusted Christian friend. The tool may feel private and nonjudgmental. That can help a person begin asking questions they have been afraid to voice. Yet private answers can also leave someone alone with a misunderstanding, especially when the question involves suffering, sin, a major life decision or a crisis of faith.

AI should not become a substitute for the Church's calling to teach, shepherd and care for people. Nor should believers assume that a polished response is spiritually neutral. The way an AI system frames a question, chooses an interpretation or leaves out a perspective can influence what the user believes—even when the answer sounds balanced.

The Church Has a Teaching Opportunity

The answer is not for churches to pretend AI does not exist. People are already using it. Churches can help believers approach it with discernment: check quoted verses in a reliable Bible, read the surrounding passage, compare claims with the whole of Scripture and consult mature Christian teachers when the question carries weight.

AI can be useful as a study aid. It might help identify unfamiliar terms, suggest questions for further reading or organize material for a Bible study. But the user should verify its claims, especially when it supplies quotations, historical details or theological conclusions. AI can be a starting point for study; it should not be treated as the final authority.

Pastors and ministry leaders can also talk openly about how they use these tools. If AI helps with research or preparation, transparency can build trust. Churches can discuss where the technology helps, where it falls short and why human relationships remain central to Christian ministry.

That creates both an opportunity and a responsibility. If someone's first question about the Bible goes to a chatbot, the Church should want that person to find faithful teaching, real community and a deeper understanding of Scripture. Technology can help open the door. It cannot walk the path of discipleship for us.

Millions may be asking AI what the Bible means. The Church's task is to help them seek answers with discernment—and to remind them that knowing Scripture is meant to lead us beyond information, into a life of faithfulness to Christ.

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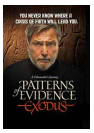
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